

Week 7: Video Transcript

Hello everyone and welcome to our seventh class session. I'm so excited that you are all back. We are continuing to weave this beautiful tapestry together and learn how to parent with empowerment, with a sense of safety and security within our bodies, hearts, and minds so we can implement all of the beautiful pillars that we have shown you, the 10 pillars of empowered parenting. I can't wait to have this conversation with you today. We are making sense of emotional intelligence and this absolutely continues the conversation from the past three weeks where we are understanding attachment. We are understanding the nervous system. We are understanding the brain, and now we're going into the heart and we're learning a brand new language of how to navigate our parenting challenges within and without with our children. Just a reminder to recap, I know the last couple of weeks have been very big and maybe brand new for you and wherever you are at in your process of really understanding what you're learning and being able to implement it in your daily life, take the pressure off. Pressure's not helpful and I trust that you are receiving this information and being able to actualize this information in the exact right and perfect time. And any kind of rushing, any kind of urgency, any longing to fix and absolutely eliminate, any slightest hint of power over or under parenting in your parenting. I understand I've been there, and my invitation for you is to recenter into trust, into safety in your body and to an expansive belief that you are right where you are meant to be along this process. It's never, ever too late. Absolutely never, ever too late. You are so supported and you are so welcome and unconditionally accepted here in this space. So let's get going.

Last week, we talked about brain science and we learned the power of the subconscious mind, and the first seven years of our life, we are essentially being programmed. Our understanding of what is true about ourselves, about intimacy, relationships, feelings, needs, our body and its ability to regulate, and what is true about the world. That's all being created through pattern and repetition through simply absorbing like a sponge, our environment, witnessing the way that our caregiver responds to us. We're not witnessing the ways that our caregiver treats themselves and takes care of themselves or interacts with life and their partner, or their co-parent, or their relatives. We're learning about what it means to be a human. We are essentially in a state of hypnosis in the first seven years of our life, and we carry those neural pathways, those truths in our brain and we're learning that the nervous system and the brain are very much entwined and they're always communicating with each other.



We have neuroception, that's taking in our environment, "Is this safe or is this dangerous?" We have our brain that is adding stories and trying to make sense of their reality, and trying to understand what is happening. Then we have the language of the heart, which is another added layer of this beautiful experience that we're having in our humanity. We are learning a brand new way of being able to be in inner peace, safety, security, and harmony through self empathy and empathy with our children. So we've learned how to become aware of what is happening when we are in secure attachment. How do we feel and how do we act when we are in avoidant attachment? How do we feel and how do we act in an ambivalent attachment or disorganized attachment? And a reminder that that's not a death statement. It's not a diagnosis. Nothing's wrong with you. We are all on this continuum and we're all making our way here and there throughout the day. It's normal.

What we're all working on is creating consistency that we are consistently in security. That's the lifelong practice. And then we're learning when to notice our nervous system, when we're going up the thermometer, when the stress levels are rising, when we're mobilizing into fight or flight, or when we're absolutely overcome into hopelessness and despair, and how to support ourselves to have nervous system resiliency and to be able to cope with stress. We learned what the brain is doing when the nervous system is activating, it's releasing cortisol and adrenaline. It's firing those neural pathways. It's taking us out of our prefrontal cortex and into the fear state of the brain, into the survival state of the brain. Now we're wanting to learn how to name our feelings and our needs, and how to allow ourselves to feel the feelings as they come and let them pass. Feelings come and go.

Remember, one component of secure attachment is trusting that our body is capable of experiencing intense sensations. Emotions, feelings, those are intense sensations, whether pleasant or unpleasant. We can get through those waves. If you are a person who has birthed a child, has experienced the laboring process, or if you're a person who has not experienced that physical laboring process, but maybe you've made a business come to life, or you're an artist and you've had a creative baby. We all know what it's like to be in those intense contractions, and the only way to get through it is to accept. What we resist, persists. So if we are fighting against it and not accepting what is happening, it gets stronger and it takes longer to pass. So we taught you these absolutely vital tools of being able to anchor yourself when you are rising in your stress responses, so you can become a safe Harbor for your child or children, and give them the gift of borrowing your calm co-regulation.

So once we get to a regulated state, we've gone through the body. We've used our calming sensory tools. Now we get to access the fun part, at least for me -- because I love talking, if you haven't noticed -- being able to communicate from the heart, being able to be heard and understood, and be effective in our language to be in integrity, autonomy, and incredible self-awareness with what's happening for us on a nuanced, ultimately complex level, which is feelings. We have six primal emotions, based on the work of Peter Levine of Somatic Experiencing and Irene Lyon, who is a master of nervous system science and neuro-plasticity. Our six primal emotions are anger, fear, sadness, happiness, disgust, and surprise. Emotions are a physiological sensation that is working in tandem with the nervous system. Is this safe? Is this dangerous? It's working in tandem to the neural pathways that are being fired and it's flooding our body with an emotional experience.

We feel emotions in our bodies and we're learning how to understand the name of that emotion so we can understand its nuances. From the six primal emotions, there are over 3000 feeling words and in the work of Dr. Marc Brackett, who is the author of *Permission to Feel*, in order for us to really actualize our self-regulation and regulation for our children, we have to have the right word for the feeling. So if we're identifying our emotion as anger, and we're identifying the feeling as uncertain, but actually the feeling is dread or anxiety. Then we're not going to get the same feeling felt, feeling heard, and feeling seen and understood. It's not going to be the right word. It's really close, but it's not quite it. You may have practiced empathy with your child where you're saying, "Oh I see that you're feeling really disappointed". And they're like, "No, that's not how I'm feeling! Stop trying to tell me what I'm feeling!" That's not it. So when we expand our vocabulary and the language of feelings, we're going to have a more attuned relationship with our experience, which creates safety and security, which floods the body with yummy feeling hormones and brings the prefrontal cortex online. It creates genius out of stress, and it softens all of those habitual neural pathways.

All of our chronic reactivity with our children is when we don't understand what's happening in our body. We don't know how to feel it, we don't know how to name it, and we don't know how to express it. So we've learned how to understand what's happening at a deep molecular level in our body. We're learning how to feel it, we're learning how to give it the right name, and then we're learning how to say it out loud. So empathy is a super power, in my opinion. It's absolutely a super power if you are using it genuinely and authentically. And that means you're really feeling it. Empathy is the ability to connect to someone else's emotional world. So while mindsight is being able to understand someone's perceptions and the way that they're interpreting and translating the world, empathy is our ability to understand and to feel what someone else is feeling.



We are attuning. Just like every other parenting tool I'm teaching you, the quality at which we can attune to our child or children depends on the quality at which we can attune to ourselves. From self empathy, flows authentic empathy. If we are lacking in self empathy, and we are trying to parent peacefully and empowered with empathy, we will end up drained, depleted, and resentful. So our priority as parents is to take care of ourselves, to really learn the skills of the new communications of feelings and needs, and I'm so excited for you to learn these with me today. We have an excellent workbook for you that you can go ahead and get out and follow along. There are many questions, many prompts for you to understand what empathy is and why it matters. We connect it to all of these incredible experiences of emotional maturity that are shown in the book, *Being a Child of An Emotionally Unavailable Parent*, and we learn what keeps us from empathy with our children. A lot of this is having conditioned beliefs about feelings and emotions. Many of us were told that feelings are bad, wrong, or they're annoying. Or when we expressed our feelings, we were not met with empathy. We were met with shame and punishment. We were met with a caregiver who only had the skills and tools to see us at our behavior. They didn't have the language of understanding what was happening for us underneath the behavior. Remember the root to bloom process. We're going into that process today, specifically to learn how to name the feelings, the needs, and the beliefs underneath every behavior. What I invite you to do is get the following words tattooed on your forehead, if you want. All behavior is our best attempt to get a need met based on our belief system. Every behavior of our child is their best attempt to get their needs met based on their development, the way that they're feeling, what their need is, and what they're believing about themselves. There is no bad behavior in our children. That's an intense thing to say, and I believe it and I stand by it. I've never felt more secure behind my language than saying that to you. While their behavior can hurt you physically, emotionally, and psychologically, it can also be very inconvenient, unproductive, unpredictable, a lot of these kinds of adjectives and labels. In order for there to be bad behavior, there must be a bad child and no child is bad. They are simply lacking the skill, the tool, and the ability. They need our help. It's our responsibility to perceive the behavior and attune to empathy.

So we're wanting to first attune to the right side of the brain, which is the feelings world. Our children are feeling their feelings in their bodies, very intensely, very viscerally. They don't have little feelings. They've got big feelings and it takes them, and they don't know how to surf. They get crashed down in the waves and they don't know how to swim, so they feel like they're drowning. Remember, we ANCHOR and we HARBOR for our child to understand, "You're not drowning. This is actually really normal and it's temporary. And I know I have the floaties, I have the life raft for you". It is my presence and my co-regulation.



Then we appeal to the left side of the brain, which is adding language, understanding, and definition. So once our child has calmed, we have non-verbal empathy by wrapping them in our warmth, our presence, and our calm. Then we can start having a conversation about feelings. So your child is probably not crying and completely distraught when you're trying to make empathy guesses of them. "Are you feeling this? What are you needing?" That's not going to work. That's going to create more frustration and stress for the both of you. So we're wanting to get them to calm and then we can say, "I'm so curious about you hitting your sister. You must have been feeling maybe scared that she was going to take your cookie. Is that how you were feeling? You were really longing to trust that your cookie was safe. Do you think that's what you were feeling in that moment?" And if our child is not being crashed by an emotion and they're not super dysregulated, they're just having a feeling flow through their body, then we can invite verbal empathy. Maybe they don't appear to be struggling, or they're not on the thermometer so high. If they're low on the thermometer, we can use verbal empathy as a preventative before they get too high, where logic is out the window.

We have the opportunity for you to go through the workbook and understand how you were received in your feelings and your emotions as a child. It's very interesting and remembering that our programming in the first seven years, we come to beliefs about whether or not it's safe to have feelings and express them. We learn that some feelings are okay to have, and some feelings are not okay to have. Our bodies learn that some feelings are safe to feel and some feelings are not, and so we learn how to push them down, which ultimately backfires and creates a lot of stress in our parenting. A daily practice right now, just in this moment, paying attention to how you feel. How is your body feeling right now? My body's feeling tight. I've been working on a computer all day. My shoulders are feeling really tense. That's my physical feeling. What's my emotion? Out of my six primary emotions, I'd say I'm feeling joy. I feel joy in my body and a feeling word, let me see if I can get three of them, a feeling word I'm having is inspiration, I feel inspired. I feel hopeful. I feel proud. The needs that are being met for me in this moment is contribution, to matter, and to be seen and heard. We can have those random check-ins throughout the day. It's really hard to have those random check-ins when you're struggling. So we want to build the muscle of being able to connect to "How's my body feeling? What's my primary emotion? What's my feeling? What's my need? We could go one step deeper, what's my belief in this moment? My belief in this moment is that I was born to serve. My offering matters. And when you're having a hard moment, I know that this is possible because I do it every day with my children. When I'm having a hard moment and I'm feeling my rise in the thermometer -- and I'm not special by the way at all, this is just practice, anyone can get here -- I can say, "What am I feeling right now? I feel my heart getting tight.



What is the emotion? I feel anger. What are the feelings? I feel frustrated. I feel resentful. I feel bitter. What are the needs? I'm longing for ease. I'm longing for teamwork. I'm longing for cooperation. What is my belief right now? That nobody cares about me. Oh, okay!" This allows us to push the pause button and redo. Self empathy is allowing yourself to have a pause button.

Being able to give yourself nonverbal, self empathy by anchoring that's the physicality and the right side of the brain. Then, give yourself the left side of the brain through verbal empathy. I talk out loud to myself all of the time, because I don't want to scream at my children. I don't want to hit my children. I don't want to call my children horrible names and humiliate them. And trust me, I want to do that sometimes. It's a conditioning in my body, but I have the ability to stop myself. There's no greater feeling than being able to stop yourself when those impulses come up. I no longer fear myself. I no longer avoid my children. I no longer live in chronic uncertainty of "Who am I going to be today? Who are my kids going to get?" And this is possible for you too. Emotional intelligence has given me freedom. It's completely transformed my children and my life. These tears are real. And every client that I've ever come across, I've had this experience, and you will have this experience too with your coach. We have beautiful examples in the workbook of a parent who yelled at their child at bedtime because they weren't able to communicate, "I'm feeling really stressed and sad. I was really hoping that we could work together as a team and make it through this transition with peace. I really believe that we're capable of this and that we know how to do this. We can be a team. How can we do this together?" If you have that skill set in your body and you have the practice, you don't have to do power over parenting. Power over parenting in the words of Marshall Rosenberg of Nonviolent Communication, power over or under parenting is a tragic strategy to meet a need. Power over parenting has been generations upon generations, the best attempt to get needs met. It's the same thing with power under. There is no shame in you falling into power over or under. It's a condition, it's a pattern, and you are now being invited to practice the way forward. I've got the path for you. And I'm so happy you're here! We're going to be practicing in the workbook, how to emotion coach your children. So when you're seeing your child in any behavior, you're going into the ANCHOR and HARBOR, and then you're supporting them through being able to validate, affirm, guess, and reflect back their feelings. And we're strengthening our children's brains. We're literally building our children's brains with every round of empathy. I'm so excited that you were all here with me today. Please enjoy your workbook. Please practice being aware of your feelings and your needs throughout your week and enjoy your session with your coach. Thank you so much.

